

Caniforms

This family of mostly carnivorous mammals includes dogs, bears, foxes, raccoons, weasels, and—perhaps surprisingly—seals, sea lions, and walruses, which evolved from bearlike ancestors. Caniform means “dog-shaped,” but early caniforms were tree-climbing animals that resembled pine martens. As they colonized the ground they evolved into more dog- and then bearlike forms.

Canis dirus

CAY-niss DIE-russ



- **When** 2 million–10,000 years ago (Late Pleistocene)
- **Fossil location** Canada, USA, Mexico
- **Habitat** Plains
- **Length** 5 ft (1.5 m)
- **Diet** Meat

Canis dirus (“dire wolf”) was a large animal with much stronger jaws and bigger teeth than modern wolves. Its limbs were shorter than those of its cousin the gray wolf, so it probably spent more time scavenging than hunting. The dire wolf died out in the last ice age, possibly because of the extinction of the large herbivores on which it fed. Thousands of fossils have been found in La Brea tar pits in California (see page 240), suggesting it was a pack hunter.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Long snouts
- Four shearing teeth at front of jaw (carnassials)
- Walked on all fours
- Most were unable to retract (pull back) their claws into a protective sheath, as cats can do.

When

They first appeared in the Paleogene Period (about 55 million years ago), and still exist today.